These, along with a few other experiences, helped deepen my understanding of politics and the Congress.

Is Politics Worth It?

About a month into the Yatra, I began to miss my family. The routine of the campaign was getting to me. Despite the fact that we were surrounded by people and fellow yatris throughout the day, I felt intensely lonely at times. On the face of it, I had made scores of new ‘friends’, but still the loneliness would not go away.

Moreover, given the ‘big tent’ character of the Congress, you got to meet people with diverse motivations and value systems. In fact, it is only within the Congress ecosystem that you could run into a dedicated Congressperson with whom you would have almost nothing in common. So most of the exchanges were restricted to small talk. It is not an exaggeration to say that there were entire days on which all I had done was walk and make small talk. Moreover, there seemed to be a culture of scoffing at serious conversations. This disheartened me, as this was my first sustained interaction with Congress functionaries within my age bracket.

I used to come back to my container and think whether this was what a life in politics was like. Would most of my life be spent making small talk with people? Was this my life in a snapshot? Would it not be better to devote this time to family and some other endeavours that would lead to more fulfilment? However, that perception changed over the next few weeks when Meenakshi Natarajan organized interactions with leaders in different states. I conducted an interaction with Dansari Seethakka, an MLA from Telangana who in the past had been an active Naxal cadre. It was fascinating to learn about her journey from an armed insurrectionist to a democratically elected representative. Similarly, in Rajasthan we got to briefly interact with the former governor of the Reserve Bank of India, Raghuram Rajan, who tried to explain complex phenomena in a simple way